

QUESTION 1

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The fennec fox is the smallest fox species in the world.
- It lives in the Sahara Desert of North Africa.
- Its ears can grow up to 15 centimeters long.
- Its large ears release excess body heat, helping it stay cool.

The student wants to explain the function of the fennec fox's ears. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The fennec fox's large ears, which can grow up to 15 centimeters long, release excess body heat and help the animal stay cool in its desert habitat.

B: Living in the Sahara Desert, the fennec fox is the smallest fox species and has ears that can reach 15 centimeters in length.

C: The fennec fox's ears can grow up to 15 centimeters, making them proportionally among the largest of any fox species in the world.

D: The fennec fox, the smallest fox species, stays cool in the Sahara thanks to its small body size and its habitat in North Africa.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: The goal is to explain function (what the ears do). A states both the size and the cooling function. B mentions size but not function. C mentions size but not the heat-release role. D attributes cooling to body size, not ears -- a misrepresentation. Trick: two options mention ear size without stating function; pick the one that says what the ears actually do.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 2

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Amara Osei is a contemporary Ghanaian textile artist.
- Her tapestry Market Morning (2018) is made of recycled cotton.
- Her tapestry Tide Lines (2021) is made of recycled cotton.
- Market Morning depicts a crowded street scene.
- Tide Lines depicts a coastal landscape.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between the two tapestries. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Amara Osei created Market Morning in 2018 and Tide Lines in 2021, both of which are tapestries depicting scenes from everyday life.

B: Amara Osei's tapestries Market Morning and Tide Lines are both made of recycled cotton.

C: Market Morning depicts a crowded street scene, while Tide Lines depicts a coastal landscape, showing Osei's range as a textile artist.

D: Market Morning and Tide Lines, created three years apart, represent different stages in Osei's career as a Ghanaian textile artist.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize a similarity. B names the shared material (recycled cotton). A says 'everyday life,' but the notes never call them that -- it is a misrepresentation. C highlights a difference, not a similarity. D discusses career stages, not a shared trait. Trick: A sounds plausible but introduces information not in the notes.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 3

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Ridgeway is an ancient trail in southern England.
- It stretches 139 kilometers.
- It has been used by travelers for at least 5,000 years.
- It passes several prehistoric monuments, including burial mounds.

The student wants to specify the length of the Ridgeway. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: An ancient trail in southern England, the Ridgeway has been walked by travelers for at least 5,000 years.

B: The Ridgeway passes several prehistoric monuments, including burial mounds, across southern England.

C: The Ridgeway, an ancient trail in southern England, stretches 139 kilometers.

D: Stretching across southern England, the Ridgeway is one of the oldest known trails, dating back millennia.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: specify length. Only C includes the 139-kilometer figure. A and D describe age but omit distance. B describes the route's features. Trick: D uses 'stretching' which sounds like it might address length, but it never gives the number.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 4

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Glass frogs and gray tree frogs are both nocturnal amphibians.
- Glass frogs avoid predators through transparency: their skin lets light pass through, making them hard to see.
- Gray tree frogs avoid predators through camouflage: their skin changes color to match bark or leaves.
- Both strategies reduce the likelihood of detection.

The student wants to emphasize a difference between the two frogs' defensive strategies. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Glass frogs and gray tree frogs are both nocturnal amphibians whose defensive strategies reduce the likelihood of detection by predators.

B: Gray tree frogs avoid predators through camouflage, changing their skin color to blend in with bark or leaves and reduce detection.

C: Both glass frogs and gray tree frogs use visual strategies -- transparency and camouflage, respectively -- to reduce the likelihood of being detected.

D: While glass frogs evade predators by letting light pass through their transparent skin, gray tree frogs do so by changing color to match bark or leaves.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize a difference. D contrasts the two mechanisms directly. A emphasizes what the frogs share (similarity). B describes only one frog. C names both strategies but frames them as a shared category (visual strategies), emphasizing similarity rather than difference. Trick: C is the strongest distractor -- it names both strategies but links them under a common label, blurring the contrast.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 5

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 2023, economist Priya Raman studied commuting patterns in Jakarta, Indonesia.
- She wanted to determine whether a new bus rapid transit (BRT) line reduced car traffic.
- She compared traffic volumes on roads parallel to the BRT line before and after it opened.
- She found that car traffic on those roads fell by 11% after the line opened.

The student wants to present the study and its findings. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Investigating whether a new bus rapid transit line in Jakarta reduced car traffic, economist Priya Raman found that traffic on parallel roads fell by 11% after the line opened.

B: Economist Priya Raman compared traffic volumes on roads parallel to a new Jakarta BRT line before and after it opened.

C: In 2023, roads parallel to a new bus rapid transit line in Jakarta carried 11% less car traffic than they had before the line opened.

D: Priya Raman studied commuting patterns in Jakarta, Indonesia, and found that a new BRT line prompted changes in how residents travel.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: present the study AND its findings. A names the researcher, the study's question, and the 11% result. B describes the method but omits the finding. C gives the finding but omits the researcher and the study context. D is vague ('changes in how residents travel') and omits the specific 11% figure. Trick: C is tempting because it has the 11% number, but it leaves out who did the study.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 6

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- A palindrome is a word or phrase that reads the same forward and backward.
- "Level" is a palindrome.
- "Racecar" is a palindrome.
- Palindromes have been found in Latin inscriptions dating to ancient Rome.

The student wants to define the term "palindrome" and provide an example. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: "Level" and "racecar" are two well-known examples of palindromes, words that have a special property.

B: Palindromes have appeared across many languages and eras, including in Latin inscriptions dating to ancient Rome.

C: A palindrome is a word or phrase that reads the same forward and backward, a feature found in many languages since ancient Rome.

D: A palindrome -- a word or phrase that reads the same forward and backward -- can be seen in words such as "level."

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: define AND give an example. D does both: states the definition and names 'level.' A gives examples but never defines what a palindrome actually is. B discusses history, not definition. C defines but gives no example word. Trick: A is tempting because it gives two examples, but it only calls them 'words that have a special property' without saying what that property is.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 7

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Marisol Duarte is an astronomer who studies exoplanets (planets outside our solar system).
- In 2024, she analyzed the atmosphere of the exoplanet Keldra-4b.
- She used transmission spectroscopy, a method that examines starlight passing through a planet's atmosphere.
- She detected water vapor in Keldra-4b's atmosphere.
- Transmission spectroscopy is a standard technique among exoplanet researchers.

The student wants to present Duarte's finding to an audience already familiar with transmission spectroscopy. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Using transmission spectroscopy -- a method that examines starlight passing through a planet's atmosphere -- Marisol Duarte detected water vapor in the atmosphere of the exoplanet Keldra-4b.

B: Marisol Duarte, an astronomer who studies exoplanets (planets outside our solar system), used transmission spectroscopy to analyze Keldra-4b in 2024.

C: Marisol Duarte's transmission spectroscopy analysis of Keldra-4b revealed water vapor in the exoplanet's atmosphere.

D: In 2024, astronomer Marisol Duarte analyzed the atmosphere of the exoplanet Keldra-4b, which is a planet outside our solar system, using a standard technique.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: present the finding to an audience that already knows what transmission spectroscopy is. C mentions the technique without defining it and states the finding (water vapor). A defines the technique, which is unnecessary for a knowledgeable audience. B omits the finding entirely. D defines 'exoplanet' and vaguely says 'a standard technique' without naming the finding. Trick: watch for unnecessary definitions -- if the audience already knows the term, defining it fails the goal.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 8

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The novelist Tomas Reyes published *The Cartographer's Daughter* in 1998.
- The novel is set in a fictional coastal village.
- Reyes published *Salt and Ash* in 2010.
- *Salt and Ash* is set in the same fictional coastal village.
- *The Cartographer's Daughter* follows a mapmaker; *Salt and Ash* follows a lighthouse keeper.

The student wants to emphasize how the two novels are connected. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Tomas Reyes published *The Cartographer's Daughter* in 1998 and *Salt and Ash* twelve years later, both novels featuring protagonists who work near the coast.

B: Tomas Reyes's novels *The Cartographer's Daughter* and *Salt and Ash* are both set in the same fictional coastal village.

C: *The Cartographer's Daughter* follows a mapmaker, whereas *Salt and Ash* follows a lighthouse keeper, showing the range of Reyes's characters.

D: Tomas Reyes's *Salt and Ash*, published in 2010, is set in a fictional coastal village and follows a lighthouse keeper.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize the connection. B states the shared setting directly. A says 'near the coast,' which is vague and not what the notes say -- the notes say 'the same fictional coastal village.' C highlights differences in characters, not a connection. D describes only one novel. Trick: A sounds like it addresses the connection ('both novels...coast') but subtly misrepresents the link; the connection is the same village, not just coastal settings.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 9

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Vertical farms grow crops indoors in stacked layers.
- They use up to 95% less water than conventional outdoor farms.
- They can operate year-round regardless of weather.
- They typically consume more electricity than conventional farms because they rely on artificial lighting.

The student wants to acknowledge a disadvantage of vertical farms. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Although vertical farms save water and operate year-round, they typically consume more electricity than conventional farms because they rely on artificial lighting.

B: Vertical farms use up to 95% less water than conventional outdoor farms and can operate year-round regardless of weather.

C: Vertical farms grow crops indoors in stacked layers and rely on artificial lighting rather than sunlight to cultivate plants.

D: Because they can operate year-round, vertical farms offer a reliable alternative to conventional outdoor farming methods.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: acknowledge a disadvantage. A names the disadvantage (higher electricity use) while also acknowledging the advantages, which is what 'acknowledge' implies -- conceding a downside in context. B lists only advantages. C mentions artificial lighting but does not frame it as a drawback. D presents year-round operation as a benefit. Trick: C is tempting because it mentions lighting, but it does not identify higher electricity consumption as a disadvantage.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 10

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Ceramicist Hana Watanabe developed her 'cracked-glaze' technique in three stages.
- In 2005, she began experimenting with rapid kiln cooling.
- In 2009, she added a mineral wash that darkened the resulting cracks.
- In 2014, she introduced a second firing that sealed the cracked surface.
- Critics praised the finished technique for its layered texture.

The student wants to emphasize the sequence of developments in Watanabe's technique. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Hana Watanabe's cracked-glaze technique, praised by critics for its layered texture, involves rapid kiln cooling, a mineral wash, and a second firing.

B: Beginning in 2005, Hana Watanabe developed a cracked-glaze technique that critics would later praise for its layered texture.

C: Hana Watanabe's cracked-glaze technique uses three methods -- rapid kiln cooling, a mineral wash, and a second firing -- to create a layered texture.

D: Watanabe first experimented with rapid kiln cooling in 2005, then added a darkening mineral wash in 2009, and finally introduced a sealing second firing in 2014.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize the sequence. D gives all three steps in chronological order with dates. A lists the steps but without dates or temporal markers, so no sequence is shown. B mentions only the start date and skips the stages. C lists the methods as a set, not a sequence. Trick: A and C both name all three methods, but listing is not sequencing -- look for temporal markers like 'first...then...finally' or dates.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 11

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Lake Baikal is located in Siberia, Russia.
- It is the deepest lake in the world, reaching 1,642 meters.
- It holds about 20% of the world's unfrozen fresh water.
- It is home to the Baikal seal, the world's only exclusively freshwater seal.

The student wants to specify how deep Lake Baikal is. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Lake Baikal holds about 20% of the world's unfrozen fresh water, making it a remarkably large freshwater body.

B: The deepest lake in the world, Lake Baikal reaches 1,642 meters.

C: Located in Siberia, Lake Baikal is notable for being the deepest lake in the world.

D: Lake Baikal, a Siberian lake that holds 20% of the world's unfrozen fresh water, is home to the Baikal seal.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: specify how deep. B gives the depth figure (1,642 meters). C calls it the deepest lake but never states the actual depth. A and D discuss water volume and the seal.

Trick: C is the main trap -- it says 'deepest' but omits the specific measurement, so it does not 'specify' the depth.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 12

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In a 2022 study, psychologist Dana Whitfield examined how background noise affects proofreading.
- Participants proofread documents in silence, in moderate cafe noise, or in loud traffic noise.
- Participants in silence caught an average of 14.2 errors.
- Participants in cafe noise caught an average of 13.9 errors.
- Participants in traffic noise caught an average of 9.1 errors.

The student wants to emphasize the condition that most impaired proofreading performance. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: In Whitfield's study, participants in silence and in cafe noise caught roughly similar numbers of errors (14.2 and 13.9, respectively).

B: Whitfield's 2022 study found that background noise affects proofreading, with participants catching fewer errors as noise levels increased.

C: Participants exposed to loud traffic noise caught an average of only 9.1 errors -- far fewer than participants in the other two conditions.

D: In 2022, Dana Whitfield examined how proofreading accuracy varies across three noise conditions: silence, cafe noise, and traffic noise.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize the most impairing condition. C isolates traffic noise and highlights the 9.1 figure as notably lower. A focuses on the similarity between silence and cafe noise, not the worst condition. B describes a general trend without specifying which condition was worst. D just introduces the study. Trick: B is tempting because it implies increasing noise is worse, but it never names the specific condition or gives the data.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 13

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Kite festivals are held in many countries.
- The Basant festival takes place in parts of South Asia.
- The Hamamatsu festival takes place in Japan.
- At the Hamamatsu festival, teams fly giant kites to celebrate the birth of children.

The student wants to introduce the Hamamatsu festival to an audience unfamiliar with it. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: At the Hamamatsu festival, held in Japan, teams fly giant kites to celebrate the birth of children.
- B: Kite festivals such as the Basant festival and the Hamamatsu festival are held in countries around the world.
- C: Teams at the Hamamatsu festival fly giant kites to celebrate the birth of children.
- D: Japan is home to kite festivals where teams fly giant kites in celebration.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: introduce Hamamatsu to an unfamiliar audience. A provides the location (Japan), the activity (flying giant kites), and the purpose (celebrating births). C omits the location, which an unfamiliar audience needs. B lumps Hamamatsu with Basant without describing it. D never names the Hamamatsu festival specifically. Trick: C looks correct but is missing the location -- an unfamiliar audience would not know where it is held.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 14

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Marine biologist Owen Castellanos studies bioluminescence (light produced by living organisms).
- Most bioluminescent ocean species emit blue light, which travels farthest in seawater.
- In 2023, Castellanos documented a deep-sea worm, *Lumenella rubra*, that emits red light.
- Red light travels poorly in seawater, so researchers had expected red bioluminescence to be rare or absent at such depths.

The student wants to explain why Castellanos's discovery surprised researchers. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Owen Castellanos, a marine biologist who studies bioluminescence, documented a deep-sea worm called *Lumenella rubra* that emits red light rather than blue.

B: Because red light travels poorly in seawater, researchers had not expected to find a deep-sea organism like *Lumenella rubra* that produces red bioluminescence.

C: Most bioluminescent ocean species emit blue light, which travels farthest in seawater, but *Lumenella rubra* is an exception that emits red light.

D: In 2023, Castellanos documented a deep-sea worm that emits red light, joining other bioluminescent species that produce light in the ocean's depths.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain why it surprised researchers. B gives the reason (red light travels poorly, so it was unexpected at depth). A states the discovery but not why it was surprising. C contrasts blue and red but does not state the reasoning behind the surprise. D misrepresents the finding by implying red-light organisms are common ('joining other'). Trick: C is a strong distractor -- it contrasts blue and red light but stops short of linking that contrast to the researchers' expectations.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 15

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Adobe is a building material made of earth, water, and organic matter such as straw.
- Adobe structures absorb heat during the day and release it at night.
- This property keeps interiors cool in daytime and warm after dark.
- Adobe has been used for centuries in hot, arid regions.

The student wants to explain an advantage of building with adobe in hot climates. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Adobe, a building material made of earth, water, and straw, has been used for centuries in hot, arid regions around the world.

B: Adobe structures absorb heat during the day, a property that results from the material's composition of earth, water, and organic matter.

C: Adobe has been widely used in hot, arid regions because it is made from locally available materials such as earth and straw.

D: Because adobe absorbs heat during the day and releases it at night, adobe buildings stay cool in daytime and warm after dark.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain an advantage in hot climates. D identifies the thermal regulation cycle and frames it as beneficial. A states history but not why it is advantageous. B mentions heat absorption but omits the release-at-night cycle and the benefit. C introduces 'locally available materials,' which is not stated in the notes -- a misrepresentation. Trick: C invents a reason (local availability) that sounds plausible but is not in the notes.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 16

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Ana Terraza (1930-2011) was a Mexican muralist.
- Her mural Rio de Voces (1968) covers a wall in Guadalajara.
- The mural depicts the history of a local river.
- It is 42 meters long.

The student wants to identify the subject of Rio de Voces. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: Ana Terraza (1930-2011) was a Mexican muralist known for her work in Guadalajara.
- B: Rio de Voces, completed in 1968, is a mural that spans 42 meters along a wall in Guadalajara.
- C: Ana Terraza's mural Rio de Voces depicts the history of a local river.
- D: The 42-meter-long Rio de Voces is one of the murals Terraza created in Guadalajara during the 1960s.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: identify the subject (what the mural depicts). C states it depicts 'the history of a local river.' A describes the artist, not the subject. B gives size and location but not the subject. D gives size and era but not the subject. Trick: B and D both sound descriptive but describe physical attributes, not what the mural actually shows.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 17

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Historian Kofi Mensah studies precolonial West African trade routes.
- He examined merchant account books from the city of Dembe dating to the 1600s.
- The account books record shipments of salt, cloth, and copper.
- Mensah concluded that Dembe's merchants traded with partners over 900 kilometers away.

The student wants to present Mensah's research and his conclusion. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Merchant account books from the city of Dembe record shipments of salt, cloth, and copper during the 1600s.

B: Precolonial West African trade involved long-distance networks, as historian Kofi Mensah has demonstrated through his research on the city of Dembe.

C: After examining seventeenth-century merchant records, Kofi Mensah found that Dembe traded salt, cloth, and copper with several other cities.

D: After examining seventeenth-century merchant account books from Dembe, historian Kofi Mensah concluded that the city's merchants traded with partners over 900 kilometers away.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: present the research AND the conclusion. D names the source (account books), the researcher, and the conclusion (900+ km trade range). A describes the sources but omits Mensah and his conclusion. B is vague ('long-distance networks') without the specific conclusion. C gives the goods traded but replaces the conclusion about distance with a vague claim ('several other cities'). Trick: C is close but swaps the specific 900-km conclusion for a weaker, unspecific claim.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 18

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Poet Iris Halvorsen published two collections in different forms.
- Wintering (2004) consists entirely of sonnets, a traditional fourteen-line form.
- Thaw (2012) consists entirely of free verse, which follows no fixed pattern.
- Both collections explore rural life in Norway.

The student wants to contrast the forms of the two collections. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Whereas Halvorsen's Wintering consists entirely of traditional fourteen-line sonnets, her later collection Thaw is written in free verse, which follows no fixed pattern.

B: Iris Halvorsen's Wintering and Thaw both explore rural life in Norway, though they were published eight years apart.

C: Iris Halvorsen published two poetry collections: Wintering in 2004, which uses sonnets, and Thaw in 2012, which explores rural Norwegian life.

D: Free verse, the form used in Halvorsen's Thaw, is distinct from the sonnet form because it follows no fixed pattern of rhyme or meter.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: contrast the forms. A directly contrasts sonnets (fixed) vs. free verse (no fixed pattern). B emphasizes a similarity (both explore rural life), not a contrast. C mentions sonnets for Wintering but describes Thaw's content, not its form. D defines free verse but does not contrast the two collections. Trick: C mentions the sonnet form for one collection but switches to describing subject matter for the other, so it fails to contrast forms.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 19

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Composer Elias Brandt wrote the symphony Northern Lights in 1978.
- The piece requires a glass harmonica, an instrument played by rubbing rotating glass bowls.
- Glass harmonicas are rare, so the symphony is seldom performed.
- In 2025, the Aurora Philharmonic acquired a glass harmonica and performed the symphony for the first time in 30 years.

The student wants to explain why Northern Lights is seldom performed and note a recent exception. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Elias Brandt's Northern Lights requires a glass harmonica, an instrument played by rubbing rotating glass bowls, and the Aurora Philharmonic performed the symphony in 2025.

B: In 2025, the Aurora Philharmonic performed Elias Brandt's Northern Lights for the first time in 30 years by acquiring the instruments the piece demands.

C: Because Northern Lights requires a rare instrument -- the glass harmonica -- it is seldom performed, though the Aurora Philharmonic staged it in 2025 after acquiring one.

D: Written in 1978, Northern Lights is a symphony by Elias Brandt that calls for an unusual instrument and has been performed only a handful of times since its premiere.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain why seldom performed AND note a recent exception. C gives the cause (rarity of the glass harmonica), the effect (seldom performed), and the exception (2025 performance). A states the requirement and the performance but does not link rarity to infrequent staging. B mentions the performance but does not state why the piece is rare. D mentions few performances but does not name the 2025 exception. Trick: A includes most pieces but never says the instrument is rare, so it does not explain 'why.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 20

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- A tessellation is a pattern of shapes that covers a surface with no gaps or overlaps.
- Honeycombs are natural tessellations made of hexagons.
- Some bathroom floors feature tessellations made of square tiles.
- The artist M.C. Escher is famous for artistic tessellations.

The student wants to provide an example of a tessellation found in nature. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Tessellations appear in many contexts, from honeycombs and bathroom floors to the art of M.C. Escher.

B: Some bathroom floors feature tessellations, which are patterns of shapes that cover a surface with no gaps or overlaps.

C: M.C. Escher is famous for creating artistic tessellations using interlocking shapes.

D: Honeycombs are natural tessellations in which hexagons cover a surface with no gaps or overlaps.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: a natural example. D names honeycombs (natural) and explains why they qualify as tessellations. A lists multiple examples without distinguishing natural from artificial. B gives a human-made example (bathroom floors). C gives an artistic example. Trick: A includes honeycombs but also non-natural examples, so it does not focus on a natural example as the goal requires.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 21

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 2024, botanist Selin Aydin surveyed wildflowers on two Turkish hillsides.
- One hillside had been grazed by goats for decades; the other had not.
- The grazed hillside hosted 34 wildflower species.
- The ungrazed hillside hosted 21 wildflower species.
- Aydin suggested that moderate grazing may prevent any single plant from dominating.

The student wants to present a possible reason for the difference in species counts. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Selin Aydin surveyed wildflowers on two Turkish hillsides in 2024, finding 34 species on one and 21 on the other.

B: According to Aydin, the grazed hillside may host more wildflower species because moderate grazing prevents any single plant from dominating.

C: The grazed hillside hosted 34 wildflower species, while the ungrazed hillside hosted only 21 species.

D: Aydin surveyed two hillsides in Turkey, one of which had been grazed by goats for decades and the other of which had not.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: present a possible reason. B gives Aydin's suggested mechanism (grazing prevents one plant from dominating). A and C present the data but not the reasoning behind it. D describes the setup but offers no reasoning. Trick: C is tempting because it highlights the gap, but highlighting the data is not the same as offering a reason for the gap.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 22

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Playwright Nadia Belmonte's *The Hourglass Room* premiered in 2019.
- The play unfolds in reverse chronological order, beginning with its final scene.
- Reverse chronology is a structure some critics associate with cinema rather than theater.
- Belmonte has said she used the structure to make audiences focus on why events happen rather than what happens next.

The student wants to present Belmonte's stated reason for using reverse chronology. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Belmonte has said she structured *The Hourglass Room* in reverse chronological order so that audiences would focus on why events happen rather than what happens next.

B: Nadia Belmonte's *The Hourglass Room*, which premiered in 2019, unfolds in reverse chronological order, beginning with its final scene.

C: Some critics associate reverse chronology with cinema, but Nadia Belmonte used it in her 2019 play *The Hourglass Room*.

D: *The Hourglass Room* begins with its final scene and works backward, a structure intended to shift how audiences experience the narrative.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: present Belmonte's stated reason. A attributes the reason to Belmonte and gives it specifically (focus on causes, not suspense). B describes the structure but not the reason. C notes the cinema association and that she used it in theater but not why. D says 'shift how audiences experience the narrative,' which is vague and does not state the specific reason. Trick: D paraphrases the reason so loosely that it loses the actual content -- 'shift how audiences experience' is too vague.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 23

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The narwhal is a whale species living in Arctic waters.
- Male narwhals have a single long tusk.
- The tusk is actually an elongated tooth.
- Tusks can grow up to 3 meters long.

The student wants to explain what a narwhal's tusk actually is. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Male narwhals have a single tusk that can grow up to 3 meters long, making it one of the most distinctive features among whale species.

B: The narwhal is a whale species found in Arctic waters, notable for the single long tusk borne by males of the species.

C: The narwhal's tusk, which can grow up to 3 meters long, is actually an elongated tooth.

D: Narwhals live in Arctic waters and are known for having tusks, which are among the longest of any marine mammal.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain what the tusk actually is. C states it is an elongated tooth. A describes size but not what the tusk is. B introduces the species and mentions the tusk but does not identify it as a tooth. D describes habitat and size but not what the tusk is. Trick: A is tempting because it gives detailed tusk information, but describing size is not the same as identifying what it is.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 24

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Sociologist Camille Fontaine studied volunteer retention at food banks in 2023.
- She surveyed 1,200 volunteers at 40 food banks in France.
- Volunteers given specific weekly roles stayed an average of 19 months.
- Volunteers assigned tasks at random each visit stayed an average of 8 months.

The student wants to emphasize a difference in how long the two groups of volunteers stayed. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Camille Fontaine surveyed 1,200 volunteers at 40 food banks across France to study how role assignment affects retention.

B: Fontaine's study found that assigning volunteers specific weekly roles is an effective strategy for increasing retention at food banks.

C: In 2023, Fontaine studied volunteer retention at food banks and found that the type of task assignment affected how long volunteers stayed.

D: Volunteers with specific weekly roles stayed an average of 19 months -- more than twice as long as volunteers assigned random tasks, who stayed an average of 8 months.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize the difference in retention. D gives both figures (19 months vs. 8 months) and highlights the gap. A describes the study design, not the findings. B makes a general claim without the specific numbers. C notes that assignment type 'affected' retention but does not quantify the difference. Trick: B and C both reference the finding but strip out the data that makes the difference vivid.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 25

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Chemist Rafael Ibarra develops water-purification membranes.
- Conventional membranes remove salt but clog quickly with organic matter.
- In 2024, Ibarra's team coated a membrane with a slippery polymer layer.
- The coated membrane resisted clogging for 300 hours -- six times longer than uncoated membranes.
- The coating did not reduce the membrane's salt-removal performance.

The student wants to emphasize that Ibarra's coating solved a problem without creating a new one. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Ibarra's polymer-coated membrane resisted clogging six times longer than uncoated membranes while removing salt just as effectively.

B: Conventional water-purification membranes remove salt but clog quickly, a problem Ibarra addressed with a slippery polymer coating in 2024.

C: In 2024, Ibarra's team coated a membrane with a slippery polymer layer that resisted clogging for 300 hours -- six times longer than uncoated membranes.

D: Ibarra's team found that a polymer coating could prevent clogging, making the membrane more durable than conventional alternatives.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: solved one problem without creating a new one. A states both that clogging was reduced AND that salt removal was maintained. B describes the problem and the solution but does not confirm that no new problem arose. C shows the clogging improvement but omits whether salt removal was preserved. D says 'more durable' but does not confirm salt performance was unharmed. Trick: C is very close but missing the crucial 'no trade-off' element.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 26

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Griot traditions are practiced in several West African cultures.
- A griot is a storyteller, musician, and oral historian.
- Griots often preserve genealogies and community histories.
- Some griots accompany their storytelling with the kora, a 21-string instrument.

The student wants to define the role of a griot. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Griots, who are found in several West African cultures, sometimes play the kora, a 21-string instrument, during their performances.

B: A griot is a storyteller, musician, and oral historian who often preserves genealogies and community histories.

C: Griot traditions are practiced in several West African cultures, where they play an important role in community life.

D: The kora, a 21-string instrument, is frequently used by griots to accompany their storytelling in West African communities.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: define the role. B gives the three-part definition (storyteller, musician, oral historian) and adds what griots preserve. A describes one activity (playing the kora) but does not define the broader role. C says 'important role' without specifying what that role is. D focuses on the kora, not the griot's role. Trick: A and D mention real griot activities but describe a single aspect rather than defining the role itself.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 27

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The city of Rotterdam built water plazas beginning in 2013.
- Water plazas are sunken public squares that double as reservoirs.
- In dry weather, they serve as basketball courts and skate parks.
- During heavy rain, they collect runoff, reducing street flooding.

The student wants to explain how water plazas serve two purposes. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Rotterdam began building water plazas -- sunken public squares designed to reduce street flooding -- in 2013.

B: Rotterdam's water plazas collect runoff during heavy rain, which significantly reduces the flooding that would otherwise affect city streets.

C: Rotterdam's water plazas function as basketball courts and skate parks in dry weather and as runoff-collecting reservoirs during heavy rain.

D: Water plazas are sunken public squares that Rotterdam has been building since 2013 to address the city's flooding challenges.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain two purposes. C names both uses: recreation (dry weather) and flood control (rain). A mentions only flood reduction. B describes only the rain function. D describes the flood motivation only. Trick: A and D are strong distractors because they define water plazas, which feels informative, but they present only one purpose.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 28

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Novelist Beatrice Okonkwo published *The Lantern Keepers* in 2015.
- The novel won the fictional Aldgate Prize in 2016.
- Okonkwo published *A Season of Smoke* in 2020.
- *A Season of Smoke* won the Aldgate Prize in 2021.
- The Aldgate Prize honors the year's best historical novel.

The student wants to emphasize Okonkwo's repeated success with the same award. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Beatrice Okonkwo published *The Lantern Keepers* in 2015 and *A Season of Smoke* in 2020, both of which are historical novels.

B: Okonkwo won the Aldgate Prize twice: for *The Lantern Keepers* in 2016 and for *A Season of Smoke* in 2021.

C: The Aldgate Prize, which honors the year's best historical novel, was awarded to *A Season of Smoke* in 2021.

D: Both of Okonkwo's novels, *The Lantern Keepers* and *A Season of Smoke*, were well received and achieved recognition for their historical narratives.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize repeated success with the same award. B names the award, states she won it twice, and gives both years. A mentions the novels but not the award. C mentions the award once, not twice. D says 'recognition' vaguely without naming the specific award. Trick: D is tempting because it mentions both novels and 'recognition,' but vague praise is not the same as naming a repeated prize.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 29

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Glaciologist Ingrid Sorensen measures glacier movement in Greenland.
- Traditional GPS stations measure movement at a few fixed points.
- In 2025, Sorensen's team laid fiber-optic cable across a glacier's surface.
- The cable detected movement continuously along its entire 12-kilometer length.
- The fiber-optic data revealed small, rapid slips that GPS stations had missed.

The student wants to emphasize an advantage of the fiber-optic method over the traditional method. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: In 2025, Sorensen's team laid fiber-optic cable across a glacier's surface to measure movement over a 12-kilometer stretch.

B: Traditional GPS stations measure glacier movement at a few fixed points, while fiber-optic cables can cover a much larger area.

C: Glaciologist Ingrid Sorensen has used both GPS stations and fiber-optic cables to study glacier movement in Greenland.

D: Unlike GPS stations, which monitor only a few fixed points, the fiber-optic cable detected movement continuously along 12 kilometers, revealing rapid slips that GPS had missed.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize an advantage of fiber-optic over GPS. D directly compares the two and names two advantages: continuous coverage and detection of slips GPS missed. A describes the fiber-optic method without comparing it to GPS. B compares area coverage but omits the 'rapid slips' advantage. C lists both methods without indicating which is better. Trick: B makes a partial comparison but leaves out the most compelling advantage (revealing otherwise-missed slips).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 30

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Quinoa is a grain crop first cultivated in the Andes Mountains.
- It was a staple food of the Inca civilization.
- Quinoa contains all nine essential amino acids.
- It grows well in poor soil and at high altitudes.

The student wants to specify where quinoa was first cultivated. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Quinoa is a grain crop that was first cultivated in the Andes Mountains.

B: Quinoa contains all nine essential amino acids and grows well in poor soil.

C: A staple food of the Inca civilization, quinoa grows well in poor soil and at high altitudes.

D: Quinoa has a long agricultural history and remains valued for its nutritional content.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: specify where first cultivated. A names the Andes Mountains as the origin. B discusses nutrition and growing conditions. C mentions the Incas (implying the region) but does not name the Andes. D is vague about location. Trick: C is tempting because 'Inca civilization' hints at the Andes, but it never states the location directly.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 31

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Antikythera mechanism is an ancient Greek device recovered from a shipwreck.
- It dates to around 100 BCE.
- It used bronze gears to predict astronomical positions and eclipses.
- Some scholars call it the world's first known analog computer.

The student wants to explain what the Antikythera mechanism did. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The Antikythera mechanism, which some scholars call the world's first analog computer, was recovered from an ancient shipwreck.

B: Dating to around 100 BCE, the Antikythera mechanism is one of the most remarkable artifacts recovered from ancient Greece.

C: Using bronze gears, the Antikythera mechanism predicted astronomical positions and eclipses.

D: Some scholars consider the Antikythera mechanism the world's first analog computer because of the complexity of its design.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain what it did (its function). C describes its function: predicting astronomical positions and eclipses using bronze gears. A gives a label (analog computer) and its recovery, not its function. B describes its age and significance. D explains why scholars call it a computer but not what it actually did. Trick: D seems like it addresses function, but 'complexity of its design' is not what it did -- it is why it received a label.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 32

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Neuroscientist Leila Farouk studies how the brain processes music.
- Trained musicians and non-musicians listened to unfamiliar melodies while their brains were scanned.
- In musicians, regions for language and for movement activated together.
- In non-musicians, only regions for hearing activated.
- Farouk proposed that musical training links listening to language and motor systems.

The student wants to explain what distinguished musicians' brain activity from non-musicians'. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: Whereas non-musicians showed activation only in hearing regions, musicians additionally showed activation in language and movement regions.
- B: Both musicians and non-musicians showed brain activation while listening to unfamiliar melodies, though the patterns differed.
- C: Leila Farouk proposed that musical training links listening to language and motor systems in the brain.
- D: Musicians' brains responded differently to unfamiliar melodies than non-musicians' brains, according to Farouk's scans.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain what distinguished the brain activity. A specifies the difference: musicians activated language and movement regions in addition to hearing. B says patterns 'differed' without specifying how. C presents Farouk's proposal, not the data that showed the distinction. D says 'differently' without detailing the specific difference. Trick: B and D both acknowledge a difference exists but withhold the specific details that answer the question.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 33

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Bioluminescent fungi glow in the dark.
- The glow is produced by a chemical reaction involving a compound called luciferin.
- One glowing fungus is the ghost fungus of Australia.
- Another is the bitter oyster of North America.

The student wants to give two examples of bioluminescent fungi. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The glow of bioluminescent fungi is produced by a chemical reaction involving a compound called luciferin.

B: The ghost fungus, a bioluminescent species found in Australia, glows in the dark due to a luciferin reaction.

C: Bioluminescent fungi produce light through chemical reactions, a trait shared by some marine organisms as well.

D: Bioluminescent fungi such as Australia's ghost fungus and North America's bitter oyster glow in the dark.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: two examples. D names both the ghost fungus and the bitter oyster. A discusses the chemical mechanism with no examples. B gives only one example. C gives no examples and adds information not in the notes (marine organisms). Trick: B is tempting because it names one example with rich detail, but the goal specifically asks for two.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 34

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Architect Yusuf Demir designed the Halden Community Library, completed in 2021.
- The library's roof is covered in solar panels.
- The panels generate more electricity than the building uses.
- Surplus electricity is fed back into the local power grid.

The student wants to explain what happens to the extra electricity the library generates. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The Halden Community Library, designed by Yusuf Demir, was completed in 2021 with a roof covered in solar panels.

B: The library's solar panels generate more electricity than the building uses, a feature Yusuf Demir incorporated into his 2021 design.

C: Surplus electricity from the library's solar panels is fed back into the local power grid.

D: Because the Halden Community Library generates more electricity than it uses, it operates at a net energy surplus.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: what happens to the extra electricity. C directly states it is fed into the local grid. A describes the building, not what happens to surplus power. B notes the surplus but does not say where it goes. D notes the surplus but also does not state what happens to it. Trick: B and D both mention the surplus, making them seem close, but neither answers 'what happens to it.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 35

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Composer Fanny Mendelssohn (1805-1847) wrote hundreds of works.
- Several were published under her brother Felix's name.
- In recent decades, scholars have reattributed many of these works to Fanny.
- The song "Italien" was long credited to Felix but was written by Fanny.

The student wants to give a specific example of a work reattributed to Fanny Mendelssohn. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: In recent decades, scholars have reattributed many works originally published under Felix Mendelssohn's name to his sister Fanny.

B: The song "Italien," long credited to Felix Mendelssohn, was in fact written by his sister Fanny.

C: Fanny Mendelssohn (1805-1847) wrote hundreds of works during her lifetime, though many were published under another name.

D: Several of Fanny Mendelssohn's compositions were published under her brother Felix's name, a practice common in the 19th century.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: give a specific example. B names 'Italien' and states the reattribution. A discusses the general trend without naming a work. C gives background without a specific example. D adds 'common in the 19th century,' which is not in the notes, and gives no specific example. Trick: A is tempting because it addresses reattribution, but 'general trend' is not a 'specific example.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 36

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Ecologist Tomasz Nowak studies beaver dams in Poland.
- Beaver dams slow the flow of streams, creating ponds.
- These ponds store water during droughts and trap sediment.
- In a drought year, streams with beaver dams kept flowing while nearby dam-free streams dried up.

The student wants to emphasize a benefit of beaver dams observed during drought. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Beaver dams slow the flow of streams, creating ponds that trap sediment and store water.

B: Tomasz Nowak has studied how beaver dams affect streams in Poland, including during periods of drought.

C: Beaver dams create ponds that serve multiple ecological functions, including sediment trapping and water storage.

D: During a drought year, streams with beaver dams kept flowing while nearby streams without dams dried up.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: benefit observed during drought. D names the specific drought-time benefit (streams kept flowing vs. drying up). A and C describe general benefits (water storage, sediment trapping) without referencing the drought observation. B says Nowak studied droughts but does not state the finding. Trick: A mentions water storage, which sounds drought-related, but it describes a general function, not the specific drought observation.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 37

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The koto is a traditional Japanese stringed instrument.
- It has 13 strings stretched over a long wooden body.
- Players pluck the strings using picks worn on the fingers.
- The koto is often played in ensemble music.

The student wants to describe how the koto is played. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Players pluck the koto's 13 strings using picks worn on the fingers.

B: The koto is a traditional Japanese stringed instrument with 13 strings stretched over a long wooden body.

C: A traditional Japanese instrument, the koto is often featured in ensemble music performances.

D: The koto has 13 strings and a long wooden body, making it one of Japan's most recognizable instruments.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: describe how it is played. A states the method (plucking with picks on fingers). B describes the instrument's construction. C and D describe its use and design. Trick: B mentions strings, which are related to playing, but it describes the instrument's physical form, not how a player produces sound.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 38

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two coral species were studied for heat tolerance.
- Acropora blue bleached when water reached 30 degrees C.
- Acropora gold did not bleach until water reached 33 degrees C.
- Bleaching occurs when corals expel the algae that provide their color and nutrients.

The student wants to emphasize a difference in the heat tolerance of the two coral species. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Both Acropora blue and Acropora gold eventually bleach when water becomes too warm, expelling the algae that give them color and nutrients.

B: Bleaching, which occurs when corals expel their algae, was observed in both Acropora blue and Acropora gold at elevated water temperatures.

C: Acropora gold tolerated warmer water than Acropora blue, bleaching only at 33 degrees C rather than 30 degrees C.

D: Acropora blue bleached when water reached 30 degrees C, demonstrating the vulnerability of coral species to rising ocean temperatures.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize a difference in heat tolerance. C directly contrasts the two species' bleaching thresholds (33 vs. 30 degrees). A and B emphasize what the two species share (both bleach). D discusses only one species. Trick: A is a good distractor -- it mentions both species and bleaching, but it frames the information as a similarity rather than a difference.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 39

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Linguist Rosa Delgado studies whistled languages.
- In some mountainous regions, people communicate across valleys by whistling.
- Whistled speech encodes the vowels and consonants of spoken words.
- On La Gomera in the Canary Islands, a whistled form of Spanish called Silbo can carry messages over 3 kilometers.

The student wants to give a specific example of a whistled language and its range. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Whistled languages, which encode the vowels and consonants of spoken words, allow people to communicate across valleys in mountainous regions such as the Canary Islands.

B: On La Gomera, a whistled form of Spanish called Silbo can carry messages over 3 kilometers.

C: Rosa Delgado studies whistled languages, including Silbo, a whistled form of Spanish found on La Gomera in the Canary Islands.

D: Whistled speech, which encodes vowels and consonants, has been documented in several mountainous regions around the world.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: specific example AND its range. B names the language (Silbo), its location (La Gomera), and its range (3 km). A mentions the Canary Islands but does not name Silbo or give the range. C names Silbo and La Gomera but omits the 3-kilometer range. D gives no specific example. Trick: C is very close -- it names Silbo and La Gomera but leaves out the range, which the goal specifically requires.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 40

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The printing press was introduced to Korea and Europe at different times.
- Korea used movable metal type by 1234, printing the Jikji text in 1377.
- Johannes Gutenberg developed his press in Europe around 1440.
- Both developments greatly increased the availability of books.

The student wants to emphasize that Korea used movable metal type before Europe did. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Korea was using movable metal type by 1234, roughly two centuries before Gutenberg developed his press in Europe around 1440.

B: Both Korea and Europe developed printing technology that greatly increased the availability of books in their respective regions.

C: Johannes Gutenberg developed his printing press in Europe around 1440, building on centuries of earlier printing innovations.

D: The Jikji text, printed in Korea in 1377, is one of the earliest known works produced with movable metal type.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize Korea came first. A gives both dates and directly states Korea was earlier. B emphasizes a similarity (both increased book availability). C focuses on Gutenberg and adds 'building on earlier innovations' (not in the notes). D mentions the Jikji but does not compare to Europe's timeline. Trick: D is tempting because 'one of the earliest' implies priority, but without mentioning Gutenberg's later date, it does not make the comparison the goal requires.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 41

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Baobab trees grow in parts of Africa, Australia, and Madagascar.
- They can store thousands of liters of water in their trunks.
- This stored water helps them survive long dry seasons.
- Some baobabs live for over a thousand years.

The student wants to explain how baobab trees survive long dry seasons. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Baobab trees grow in parts of Africa, Australia, and Madagascar, regions that often experience long dry seasons.

B: Some baobab trees live for over a thousand years, making them among the longest-lived tree species in the world.

C: Baobab trees can store thousands of liters of water in their trunks, which have an unusually wide and barrel-shaped form.

D: By storing thousands of liters of water in their trunks, baobab trees survive long dry seasons.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain how they survive dry seasons. D links water storage to drought survival. A describes habitat but not the survival mechanism. B discusses lifespan. C mentions water storage but never connects it to surviving droughts. Trick: C is the main trap -- it has the key fact (water storage) but stops short of linking it to the goal (surviving dry seasons).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 42

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Filmmaker Aisha Rahman directed the documentary Salt Roads in 2022.
- The film follows caravans that transport salt across the Sahara.
- Rahman filmed over 14 months, traveling with the caravans.
- Salt Roads won a fictional award for cinematography at the Meridian Film Festival.

The student wants to describe the subject of Salt Roads. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Aisha Rahman spent 14 months filming Salt Roads, traveling alongside the documentary's subjects across the Sahara.

B: Salt Roads won an award for cinematography at the Meridian Film Festival, reflecting the visual quality of Rahman's work.

C: Salt Roads, directed by Aisha Rahman, follows caravans that transport salt across the Sahara.

D: Aisha Rahman's 2022 documentary Salt Roads was praised for its cinematography and its immersive approach to filming.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: describe the subject (what the film is about). C states the subject: caravans transporting salt across the Sahara. A describes the filming process, not the subject. B discusses the award. D discusses praise and style. Trick: A is tempting because 'traveling alongside subjects' hints at the content, but it describes how the film was made, not what it is about.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 43

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Materials scientist Hugo Berg studies self-healing concrete.
- Ordinary concrete cracks over time, and cracks let in water that corrodes steel reinforcement.
- Berg's concrete contains capsules of bacteria that produce limestone.
- When cracks form and water enters, the bacteria activate and fill the cracks with limestone.
- In tests, Berg's concrete sealed cracks up to 0.8 millimeters wide.

The student wants to explain the mechanism by which Berg's concrete heals itself. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Hugo Berg's self-healing concrete sealed cracks up to 0.8 millimeters wide in laboratory tests, outperforming ordinary concrete.

B: In Berg's concrete, cracks and incoming water activate embedded bacteria that fill the gaps with limestone.

C: Ordinary concrete cracks over time, allowing water to seep in and corrode the steel reinforcement inside.

D: Hugo Berg developed a concrete that contains capsules of bacteria, making it more durable than ordinary concrete.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain the mechanism (how it works). B describes the trigger (cracks + water), the agent (bacteria), and the action (fill with limestone). A gives the result (0.8 mm) but not the mechanism. C describes the problem with ordinary concrete, not the healing mechanism. D says it contains bacteria but does not describe what the bacteria do or how healing occurs. Trick: D is close -- it names the key ingredient (bacteria capsules) but never describes the process by which healing actually happens.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 44

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The dodo was a flightless bird that lived on the island of Mauritius.
- It went extinct in the late 1600s.
- It was about one meter tall.
- It had no natural predators before humans arrived on the island.

The student wants to specify where the dodo lived. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The dodo was a flightless bird that lived on the island of Mauritius.

B: The dodo, which went extinct in the late 1600s, was about one meter tall and had no natural predators.

C: Before humans arrived, the dodo had no natural predators on its home island.

D: The dodo went extinct in the late 1600s, shortly after humans began arriving at its island habitat.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: specify where it lived. A names Mauritius directly. B gives size and predator info but no location. C says 'its home island' without naming it. D says 'its island habitat' without naming it. Trick: C and D both refer to an island, which seems location-related, but neither names the specific island.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 45

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 2023, agronomist Bao Lin tested two irrigation schedules on rice paddies.
- Paddies watered continuously used 1,200 liters of water per kilogram of rice.
- Paddies watered intermittently used 780 liters per kilogram of rice.
- Rice yields were nearly identical under both schedules.

The student wants to emphasize that intermittent watering saved water without reducing yield. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Bao Lin tested two irrigation schedules on rice paddies in 2023, comparing continuous and intermittent watering methods.

B: Rice paddies watered continuously used 1,200 liters of water per kilogram of rice, according to Bao Lin's 2023 study.

C: In Bao Lin's study, rice yields were nearly identical whether paddies were watered continuously or intermittently.

D: Intermittent watering used far less water -- 780 liters per kilogram versus 1,200 -- while producing nearly identical rice yields.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: saved water WITHOUT reducing yield (two-part goal). D gives both: the water savings (780 vs. 1,200) and the yield result (nearly identical). A introduces the study without results. B gives only the continuous-watering figure. C addresses yield only, not water savings. Trick: C addresses half the goal (yield was the same) but ignores the other half (water savings).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 46

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two theories explain why zebras have stripes.
- The 'cooling theory' holds that stripes create air currents that cool the animal.
- The 'fly theory' holds that stripes deter biting flies, which struggle to land on striped surfaces.
- A 2019 experiment found that flies landed far less often on striped surfaces than on solid ones.
- The experiment offered no evidence for the cooling theory.

The student wants to note which theory the 2019 experiment supported. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: Two theories -- the cooling theory and the fly theory -- attempt to explain why zebras have stripes.
- B: A 2019 experiment found that flies landed far less often on striped surfaces, though the experiment did not address whether stripes affect body temperature.
- C: The 2019 experiment supported the fly theory, finding that flies landed far less often on striped surfaces than on solid ones.
- D: The cooling theory, which holds that stripes create air currents, was one of two theories tested in a 2019 experiment about zebra stripes.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: note which theory was supported. C names the fly theory and cites the supporting evidence. A introduces both theories without the experiment's results. B gives the finding but never names which theory it supports. D focuses on the cooling theory and does not state the experiment's conclusion. Trick: B is a strong distractor -- it gives the experiment's data but never explicitly connects the finding to the fly theory.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 47

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Origami is the Japanese art of paper folding.
- A single sheet of paper is folded into shapes without cutting or gluing.
- Traditional origami includes designs like the crane and the frog.
- Modern origami has influenced fields such as engineering.

The student wants to define origami. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Traditional origami includes designs like the crane and the frog, and modern origami has influenced engineering.

B: Origami is the Japanese art of folding a single sheet of paper into shapes without cutting or gluing.

C: Modern origami has influenced fields such as engineering, expanding the art form beyond its traditional roots.

D: Origami designs such as the crane and the frog demonstrate the range of shapes that can be created through paper folding.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: define origami. B provides the definition: Japanese art, single sheet, no cutting or gluing. A gives examples and influence but not a definition. C discusses modern influence. D gives examples without defining the art. Trick: A is tempting because it covers multiple facts about origami, but listing examples is not defining the term.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 48

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Voynich manuscript is a book written in an unknown script.
- It dates to the early 1400s.
- Despite many attempts, no one has deciphered its text.
- Its pages contain illustrations of plants, stars, and figures.

The student wants to emphasize that the manuscript remains undeciphered. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Despite many attempts over the centuries, no one has been able to decipher the Voynich manuscript's unknown script.

B: The Voynich manuscript, which dates to the early 1400s, is written in a script that scholars have studied extensively.

C: The Voynich manuscript contains illustrations of plants, stars, and figures alongside its mysterious text.

D: Dating to the early 1400s, the Voynich manuscript is written in a script that differs from any known writing system.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize it remains undeciphered. A highlights the failure to decipher despite many attempts. B says 'studied extensively' but does not state the outcome of that study. C describes illustrations, not decipherment. D describes the script's uniqueness but not whether it has been decoded. Trick: B is the main trap -- 'studied extensively' implies ongoing work but avoids saying the work has failed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 49

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Engineer Mei-Ling Chou designs earthquake-resistant buildings.
- One method she uses is base isolation, placing flexible bearings between a building and its foundation.
- The bearings absorb ground motion, reducing shaking in the building above.
- A hospital she designed with base isolation stayed operational after a major earthquake.

The student wants to explain how base isolation protects a building. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Mei-Ling Chou designed a hospital with base isolation that stayed operational after a major earthquake.

B: Mei-Ling Chou uses base isolation, one of several methods for designing earthquake-resistant buildings.

C: Base isolation places flexible bearings between a building and its foundation, where they absorb ground motion and reduce shaking in the building above.

D: A hospital designed with base isolation by Mei-Ling Chou demonstrated the method's effectiveness during a major earthquake.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain how base isolation works. C describes the mechanism: bearings between building and foundation absorb ground motion. A gives a result (hospital stayed operational) but not the mechanism. B names the method without describing it. D discusses the result, not the mechanism. Trick: A and D both show base isolation worked, but showing that something worked is not the same as explaining how it works.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 50

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Anthropologist Nadia Petrov studied a fishing community on Lake Malawi.
- The community follows a rule: no fishing in a designated cove from October to December.
- During those months, fish spawn in the cove.
- Petrov found that fish populations were more stable in this community than in neighboring communities without the rule.

The student wants to explain how the community's rule affects fish populations. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Nadia Petrov compared fish populations in a Lake Malawi community with those in neighboring communities.

B: By banning fishing in a spawning cove from October to December, the community keeps its fish populations more stable than those of neighboring communities without the rule.

C: The Lake Malawi community prohibits fishing in a designated cove from October to December, a period when fish use the cove for spawning.

D: Petrov found that neighboring communities on Lake Malawi had less stable fish populations, possibly due to differences in fishing practices.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain how the rule affects populations. B connects the rule (ban during spawning) to the outcome (more stable populations) and compares with neighbors. A describes the study design, not the effect. C describes the rule and the spawning but does not state the population outcome. D gives the outcome for neighbors but is vague about the cause. Trick: C is the strongest distractor -- it gives the rule and the spawning context but stops before stating the population effect.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 51

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Great Barrier Reef is located off the coast of Australia.
- It stretches over 2,300 kilometers.
- It is the world's largest coral reef system.
- It is home to thousands of marine species.

The student wants to specify the length of the Great Barrier Reef. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The Great Barrier Reef, the world's largest coral reef system, is located off the coast of Australia.

B: The Great Barrier Reef is home to thousands of marine species across its vast expanse.

C: As the world's largest coral reef system, the Great Barrier Reef is a significant marine ecosystem off Australia's coast.

D: The Great Barrier Reef stretches over 2,300 kilometers off the coast of Australia.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: specify the length. D states 2,300 kilometers. A says 'largest' but omits the measurement. B and C describe biodiversity and significance. Trick: A and C both call it 'the largest,' which relates to size but never gives the specific length.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 52

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Poet Junot Vega writes in two languages.
- His collection *Frontera* (2016) alternates between English and Spanish poems.
- His collection *Umbrales* (2020) mixes both languages within single poems.
- Critics say this blending reflects the experience of living between cultures.

The student wants to contrast how the two collections use language. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: Whereas *Frontera* alternates between separate English and Spanish poems, *Umbrales* mixes both languages within single poems.
- B: Critics say Junot Vega's blending of English and Spanish reflects the experience of living between cultures.
- C: Junot Vega's *Frontera* and *Umbrales* both incorporate English and Spanish, reflecting his bilingual writing practice.
- D: Vega published *Frontera* in 2016 and *Umbrales* in 2020, both collections demonstrating his interest in bilingual poetry.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: contrast how they use language. A directly contrasts: *Frontera* separates the languages, *Umbrales* blends them. B discusses critical interpretation, not a contrast of methods. C emphasizes a similarity (both use both languages). D gives dates and a shared theme. Trick: C is a strong distractor -- it names both collections and both languages but frames the information as a shared trait, not a contrast.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 53

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Physicist Amara Nwosu studies the acoustics of ancient theaters.
- The theater at Epidaurus in Greece is famous for its clear sound.
- Nwosu found that the theater's stone seats filter out low-frequency background noise.
- The seats also reflect the higher frequencies of a speaker's voice toward the audience.
- Together, these effects let audiences hear performers clearly even from the back rows.

The student wants to explain how the theater's seats improve what audiences hear. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Amara Nwosu studies the acoustics of ancient theaters, including the famous theater at Epidaurus in Greece.

B: Audiences at the theater at Epidaurus can hear performers clearly even from the back rows, making it famous for its sound quality.

C: The theater at Epidaurus achieves its famous acoustic clarity through features of its stone construction, according to physicist Amara Nwosu.

D: The theater's stone seats filter out low-frequency background noise while reflecting the higher frequencies of a speaker's voice toward the audience.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain how the seats improve sound. D describes both acoustic effects: filtering low frequencies and reflecting high frequencies. A introduces the researcher, not the mechanism. B states the result (clear hearing) without the mechanism. C attributes clarity to 'features of stone construction' but does not specify the dual frequency effect. Trick: C sounds like a mechanism but is too vague -- it says 'features' without naming them.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 54

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Saffron is a spice made from the crocus flower.
- Each flower produces only three red stigmas, which are harvested by hand.
- It takes about 150 flowers to make one gram of saffron.
- This labor makes saffron one of the world's most expensive spices.

The student wants to explain why saffron is so expensive. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Saffron is a spice made from the red stigmas of the crocus flower.

B: Saffron is one of the world's most expensive spices and has been prized for centuries.

C: Because each crocus yields only three hand-harvested stigmas, it takes about 150 flowers to make one gram of saffron -- labor that makes it very expensive.

D: Each crocus flower produces three red stigmas that are harvested by hand, a delicate process carried out during a brief harvest window.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain why it is expensive. C links the small yield per flower to the large number of flowers needed, then connects that to cost. A identifies the source but not the cost. B states it is expensive without saying why. D describes the harvest process but does not connect it to cost. Trick: D is tempting because it mentions the labor-intensive harvest, but it never states that this drives the price.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 55

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Historian Yara Haddad studies medieval trade fairs in Europe.
- The Champagne fairs in France ran for several weeks at a time.
- Merchants from across Europe met there to trade goods and settle debts.
- Special courts at the fairs resolved disputes quickly so trade could continue.

The student wants to explain the purpose of the special courts at the Champagne fairs. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The Champagne fairs in France ran for several weeks, drawing merchants from across Europe to trade goods.

B: Special courts at the Champagne fairs resolved disputes quickly so that trade could continue without lengthy interruptions.

C: Merchants from across Europe met at the Champagne fairs to trade goods, settle debts, and resolve any disputes that arose.

D: Yara Haddad studies medieval trade fairs in Europe, including the Champagne fairs in France.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain the purpose of the courts. B states the purpose: resolve disputes quickly to keep trade flowing. A describes the fairs generally. C mentions dispute resolution but attributes it to the merchants rather than the special courts. D introduces the historian. Trick: C is the main trap -- it mentions resolving disputes but incorrectly attributes this to the merchants gathering rather than to the dedicated courts.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 56

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two methods can date old timber.
- Radiocarbon dating measures the decay of carbon-14 and gives a range of possible years.
- Dendrochronology matches a timber's tree-ring pattern to a regional master record, giving an exact year.
- A team dated a Norwegian ship's timbers using both methods.
- Dendrochronology pinpointed the felling year as 1204; radiocarbon dating gave a range of 1180-1230.

The student wants to emphasize that dendrochronology gave a more precise date than radiocarbon dating. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: For the ship's timbers, dendrochronology pinpointed a felling year of 1204, whereas radiocarbon dating gave only a broad range of 1180-1230.

B: The team used both radiocarbon dating and dendrochronology to date the Norwegian ship's timbers, obtaining results from each method.

C: Radiocarbon dating measures the decay of carbon-14 and typically produces a range of possible dates rather than a single year.

D: Dendrochronology, which matches tree-ring patterns to a master record, and radiocarbon dating, which measures carbon-14 decay, are two methods for dating old timber.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize dendrochronology was more precise. A directly contrasts the results: exact year (1204) vs. range (1180-1230). B says both methods were used but does not compare precision. C describes radiocarbon only. D defines both methods without comparing their results. Trick: D seems thorough because it describes both methods, but it never presents the results that demonstrate the precision difference.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 57

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The axolotl is a type of salamander native to lakes near Mexico City.
- Unlike most amphibians, it keeps its larval features throughout its life.
- It can regrow lost limbs, and even parts of its heart and brain.
- It is critically endangered in the wild.

The student wants to describe the axolotl's ability to regrow body parts. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The axolotl is a critically endangered salamander native to lakes near Mexico City that retains its larval features throughout life.

B: The axolotl can regrow lost limbs and even parts of its heart and brain.

C: Native to lakes near Mexico City, the axolotl is unique among amphibians because it keeps its larval features into adulthood.

D: The axolotl, a salamander that is critically endangered in the wild, has several unusual biological traits.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: describe the regrowth ability. B directly states what it can regrow: limbs, heart, brain. A discusses habitat and larval features. C discusses larval features. D vaguely mentions 'unusual traits' without specifying. Trick: D is the sneakiest trap -- 'unusual biological traits' technically includes the regrowth ability, but it never names it.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 58

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two bridges span the same river gorge.
- The Old Span, built in 1890, is a stone arch bridge that carries only pedestrians.
- The New Span, built in 2015, is a steel cable bridge that carries vehicles.
- Both bridges are still in use today.

The student wants to emphasize a difference in what the two bridges carry. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The Old Span, a stone arch bridge, was built in 1890, and the New Span, a steel cable bridge, was built in 2015.

B: Both the Old Span and the New Span remain in use today, spanning the same river gorge for different types of traffic.

C: The Old Span carries only pedestrians, whereas the New Span carries vehicles.

D: Built 125 years apart, the Old Span and the New Span use different construction methods: stone arches and steel cables, respectively.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: difference in what they carry. C directly contrasts pedestrians vs. vehicles. A contrasts construction materials and dates, not cargo. B says 'different types of traffic' but does not specify what each carries. D contrasts construction methods. Trick: B is the best distractor -- 'different types of traffic' implies the answer but never states it explicitly.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 59

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Economist Farida Osei examined microloans in rural Ghana.
- Microloans are small loans given to people who lack access to traditional banks.
- Borrowers who received financial training alongside their loans repaid at a rate of 94%.
- Borrowers who received loans without training repaid at a rate of 71%.
- Osei concluded that training, not the loan alone, drove higher repayment.

The student wants to present Osei's conclusion about what drove higher repayment. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Osei concluded that financial training, rather than the loan alone, drove the higher repayment rates she observed.

B: Borrowers who received training repaid at 94%, while those without training repaid at 71%, a significant gap in repayment rates.

C: Farida Osei examined microloans in rural Ghana, comparing borrowers who received financial training with those who did not.

D: Microloans in rural Ghana were more effective when paired with financial training, as the 94% repayment rate demonstrates.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: present Osei's conclusion about what drove repayment. A attributes the conclusion to Osei and states it clearly: training, not the loan alone. B presents the data but not the conclusion drawn from it. C describes the study design. D states training helped but does not attribute this as Osei's conclusion and omits the 'not the loan alone' contrast.

Trick: D is close but presents a general observation rather than Osei's specific conclusion, and it loses the key contrast (training vs. loan alone).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 60

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Sami are an Indigenous people of northern Scandinavia.
- Many Sami have traditionally herded reindeer.
- The Sami language includes many words for snow and ice.
- Sami handicrafts are known as duodji.

The student wants to specify what Sami handicrafts are called. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The Sami are an Indigenous people of northern Scandinavia known for traditions such as reindeer herding.

B: Many Sami have traditionally herded reindeer, and their language includes many words for snow and ice.

C: The Sami, an Indigenous people of northern Scandinavia, have a rich tradition of handicrafts and cultural practices.

D: Sami handicrafts are known as duodji.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: specify the name. D gives the name 'duodji' directly. A and B discuss other Sami traditions. C mentions handicrafts but does not give the name. Trick: C is the main trap -- it refers to handicrafts but withholds the specific term, so it fails the 'specify' requirement.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 61

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Astronomer Deshi Yuan searches for asteroids near Earth.
- In 2024, his team discovered an asteroid named 2024 QF.
- The asteroid is about 400 meters wide.
- It orbits the Sun once every 3.2 years.
- Its orbit does not bring it close enough to threaten Earth.

The student wants to reassure readers about the asteroid's threat level. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: In 2024, Deshi Yuan's team discovered 2024 QF, an asteroid about 400 meters wide that orbits the Sun every 3.2 years.

B: Although 2024 QF is about 400 meters wide, its orbit does not bring it close enough to threaten Earth.

C: Deshi Yuan searches for asteroids near Earth, and in 2024 his team discovered one named 2024 QF.

D: The asteroid 2024 QF, discovered by Deshi Yuan's team, is about 400 meters wide and orbits the Sun every 3.2 years.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: reassure about threat level. B acknowledges the size (which could seem alarming) and then states it poses no threat -- the structure itself is reassuring. A gives factual details without addressing threat. C introduces the discovery. D describes size and orbit without a safety statement. Trick: A and D give size data that might seem relevant but never state whether the asteroid is a threat.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 62

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two types of symbols were used to write the ancient Maya language.
- Logograms are symbols that each represent a whole word.
- Syllabograms are symbols that each represent a syllable.
- Maya scribes combined both types in a single text.
- This combination allowed scribes to write almost any word in their language.

The student wants to explain how combining the two symbol types benefited Maya scribes. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Maya scribes used logograms, which represent whole words, and syllabograms, which represent syllables, to write their language.

B: Logograms represent whole words, while syllabograms represent syllables -- two complementary symbol types in Maya writing.

C: By combining logograms and syllabograms in a single text, Maya scribes could write almost any word in their language.

D: The ancient Maya language was recorded using two distinct types of written symbols that scribes deployed throughout their texts.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain the benefit of combining them. C states the benefit: scribes could write almost any word. A defines the symbols but does not state the benefit of combining. B defines and contrasts but stops before the benefit. D says two types were used but gives no benefit. Trick: A is very close -- it accurately describes the system but omits the key payoff (writing almost any word).

END QUESTION

QUESTION 63

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Bamboo is one of the fastest-growing plants on Earth.
- Some species can grow nearly a meter in a single day.
- Bamboo is technically a type of grass.
- It is used for construction, furniture, and food.

The student wants to emphasize how quickly bamboo can grow. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Some bamboo species can grow nearly a meter in a single day, making bamboo one of the fastest-growing plants on Earth.

B: Bamboo, which is technically a type of grass, is used for construction, furniture, and food.

C: Bamboo is one of the fastest-growing plants on Earth and is technically classified as a grass rather than a tree.

D: Used for construction, furniture, and food, bamboo is remarkable for being technically a type of grass.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize growth speed. A gives the specific rate (nearly a meter per day) and the superlative (fastest-growing). C calls it fastest-growing but omits the specific rate. B and D discuss classification and uses. Trick: C is the main distractor -- it says 'fastest-growing' but without the dramatic per-day figure, it does not emphasize the speed as powerfully.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 64

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Painter Leonor Fini created stage costumes and set designs.
- Her 1948 designs for a ballet used bold geometric patterns.
- Her 1965 designs for an opera used flowing, organic shapes.
- Both projects were praised for their striking colors.

The student wants to contrast the visual style of the two projects. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Leonor Fini created stage costumes and set designs for both ballet and opera productions over the course of her career.

B: Both of Fini's projects -- her 1948 ballet designs and her 1965 opera designs -- were praised for their striking colors.

C: Fini's 1965 opera designs used flowing, organic shapes and striking colors that brought the production to life.

D: Whereas Fini's 1948 ballet designs used bold geometric patterns, her 1965 opera designs used flowing, organic shapes.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: contrast visual styles. D directly contrasts geometric (ballet) vs. organic (opera). A introduces both projects without contrasting styles. B emphasizes a shared trait (colors). C describes only one project. Trick: B is a strong distractor because it mentions both projects, but it highlights a similarity rather than a contrast.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 65

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Biologist Kenji Sato studies how ants navigate.
- Desert ants of the genus *Cataglyphis* find their way home in a straight line after wandering to find food.
- Sato found that these ants count their steps to estimate distance traveled.
- When Sato lengthened the ants' legs with tiny stilts, they overshoot their nests.
- This overshooting supported the idea that the ants measure distance by counting steps.

The student wants to explain how the stilt experiment supported the step-counting idea. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Kenji Sato studies how desert ants of the genus *Cataglyphis* navigate back to their nests after finding food.

B: Sato found that desert ants count their steps to estimate distance, a conclusion he tested using an experiment involving stilts.

C: When Sato lengthened the ants' legs with stilts, they overshoot their nests -- as expected if the ants gauge distance by counting steps, since longer legs cover more ground per step.

D: Desert ants of the genus *Cataglyphis* use a step-counting mechanism to navigate home, according to biologist Kenji Sato.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain how the experiment supported the idea. C gives the method (stilts), the result (overshooting), and the logical connection (longer legs = more ground per step = overshooting if counting steps). B mentions the experiment but does not explain how it supports the idea. A and D state the navigation method without the experimental support. Trick: B acknowledges the experiment exists but never explains the logic of why overshooting supports step-counting.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 66

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Trans-Siberian Railway crosses Russia from west to east.
- It is the longest railway line in the world.
- It runs about 9,289 kilometers.
- The full journey takes about a week.

The student wants to specify how long the Trans-Siberian Railway is. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Crossing Russia from west to east, the Trans-Siberian Railway is the longest railway line in the world.

B: The Trans-Siberian Railway runs about 9,289 kilometers across Russia.

C: The full journey on the Trans-Siberian Railway takes about a week as the train crosses Russia from west to east.

D: The Trans-Siberian Railway, which crosses all of Russia, holds the record as the world's longest railway line.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: specify the length. B gives the figure (9,289 km). A and D call it 'longest' but omit the number. C gives travel time, not distance. Trick: A and D both say 'longest' which relates to length, but they never give the specific measurement the goal requires.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 67

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 2023, chef and researcher Paolo Greco studied bread staling.
- Bread goes stale as starch molecules recrystallize and lose moisture.
- Greco found that storing bread at room temperature kept it fresh longest.
- Refrigerating bread made it go stale faster than leaving it at room temperature.

The student wants to share Greco's finding about the best way to store bread. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Greco found that storing bread at room temperature kept it fresh longest, whereas refrigerating it made it stale faster.

B: Bread goes stale as starch molecules recrystallize and lose moisture, a process that Greco studied in 2023.

C: In 2023, Paolo Greco studied the chemical process behind bread staling, focusing on starch recrystallization.

D: Refrigerating bread affects how quickly starch molecules recrystallize, which in turn influences how long the bread stays fresh.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: share Greco's finding about best storage. A states the finding (room temperature is best) and contrasts it with refrigeration. B describes the science of staling. C describes the study topic. D discusses refrigeration's effect vaguely without stating Greco's finding. Trick: D sounds scientific and mentions refrigeration, but it never states whether refrigeration helps or hurts, nor does it give Greco's conclusion.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 68

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two dyeing traditions produce blue cloth.
- Indigo dyeing, used in West Africa, ferments plant leaves to produce a deep blue.
- Woad dyeing, used in medieval Europe, uses a different plant to produce a paler blue.
- Both traditions were labor-intensive and highly valued.
- Chemically, both dyes deposit the same blue compound, indigotin, on the cloth.

The student wants to emphasize an underlying chemical similarity between the two dyeing traditions. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Indigo dyeing produces a deep blue, while woad dyeing produces a paler blue, yet both traditions were labor-intensive and highly valued.

B: Indigo dyeing was used in West Africa, and woad dyeing was used in medieval Europe, but both traditions produced blue cloth.

C: Both indigo and woad dyeing are labor-intensive traditions that were highly valued for the blue cloth they produced.

D: Despite using different plants, both indigo and woad dyeing deposit the same blue compound, indigotin, on the cloth.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize a chemical similarity. D names the shared compound (indigotin) and contrasts it with the different plants. A emphasizes a visual difference (deep vs. pale) and a cultural similarity (labor-intensive), not a chemical one. B notes both produce blue cloth but does not mention chemistry. C gives a cultural similarity (labor-intensive). Trick: B is tempting -- 'both produced blue cloth' is a similarity, but it is visual, not chemical.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 69

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The kakapo is a large, flightless parrot from New Zealand.
- It is nocturnal, active mainly at night.
- It is one of the world's rarest birds.
- Conservationists track each surviving kakapo individually.

The student wants to explain when the kakapo is most active. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: The kakapo, one of the world's rarest birds, is tracked individually by conservationists.
- B: Conservationists track each surviving kakapo because it is one of the world's rarest and most endangered birds.
- C: The kakapo is nocturnal, meaning it is active mainly at night.
- D: The kakapo is a large, flightless parrot found only in New Zealand.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: when it is most active. C states it is nocturnal (active at night). A and B discuss conservation tracking. D describes the species but not its activity pattern. Trick: none of the distractors are especially tempting here -- this is a straightforward identification question at Easy difficulty.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 70

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The city of Freiburg redesigned a neighborhood called Vauban in the 1990s.
- Cars are banned from most streets in Vauban.
- Residents rely on trams, bicycles, and walking.
- Surveys show most Vauban households own no car.

The student wants to explain how residents of Vauban get around. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Freiburg redesigned the Vauban neighborhood in the 1990s, creating a community with a distinctive approach to transportation.

B: Surveys show that most households in Vauban own no car, a statistic that reflects the neighborhood's design.

C: Cars are banned from most streets in the Vauban neighborhood, which Freiburg redesigned in the 1990s.

D: In Vauban, where most streets ban cars, residents rely on trams, bicycles, and walking.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: how residents get around. D names the modes (trams, bicycles, walking) and the context (car ban). A says 'distinctive approach' without specifying what it is. B discusses car ownership, not how people travel. C states the ban but not what residents use instead. Trick: C is close -- banning cars implies alternative transport, but it never states what those alternatives are.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 71

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Geneticist Ravi Kapoor studies wheat varieties.
- An older wheat variety, Emmer, resists a fungal disease but produces low yields.
- A modern variety, Sunbelt, produces high yields but is vulnerable to the fungus.
- Kapoor crossed the two varieties to combine disease resistance with high yield.
- The resulting variety resisted the fungus and yielded nearly as much as Sunbelt.

The student wants to explain the goal and result of Kapoor's crossbreeding. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: By crossing disease-resistant Emmer with high-yield Sunbelt, Kapoor produced a variety that resisted the fungus while yielding nearly as much as Sunbelt.

B: Ravi Kapoor studies wheat varieties, including the older Emmer and the modern Sunbelt, which have complementary strengths and weaknesses.

C: Emmer resists a fungal disease but produces low yields, while Sunbelt produces high yields but is vulnerable to the same fungus.

D: Kapoor crossed two wheat varieties to produce a new strain with improved characteristics, combining traits from each parent variety.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: the goal AND the result. A states the goal (combine resistance with yield) and the result (resisted fungus, yielded nearly as much as Sunbelt). B describes the varieties without the cross or its result. C describes the problem, not the cross or its result. D is vague ('improved characteristics') without naming what those characteristics are. Trick: D says 'combining traits' which sounds right, but it withholds the specific traits and results.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 72

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Petra is an ancient city in present-day Jordan.
- Its buildings were carved directly into rose-colored sandstone cliffs.
- It was a major trading hub around 2,000 years ago.
- Today it is a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

The student wants to describe how Petra's buildings were made. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Petra, an ancient city in present-day Jordan, was a major trading hub around 2,000 years ago.

B: Petra's buildings were carved directly into rose-colored sandstone cliffs.

C: Today Petra is a UNESCO World Heritage Site located in present-day Jordan.

D: Petra, a UNESCO World Heritage Site, was a major trading hub and is known for its distinctive architecture.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: describe how they were made. B states the construction method (carved into sandstone cliffs). A discusses trade history. C gives modern status. D mentions 'distinctive architecture' but does not describe how it was made. Trick: D says 'distinctive architecture,' which hints at the construction method, but it never states how the buildings were actually made.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 73

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two lighthouses guard a stretch of rocky coast.
- The North Light flashes twice every ten seconds.
- The South Light flashes once every ten seconds.
- The different flash patterns let sailors tell the two lighthouses apart.

The student wants to explain why the two lighthouses have different flash patterns. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The North Light flashes twice every ten seconds, while the South Light flashes once every ten seconds.

B: Two lighthouses with distinct flash patterns guard a stretch of rocky coast.

C: The two lighthouses flash in different patterns so that sailors can tell them apart.

D: The North Light and the South Light both flash at ten-second intervals, though their patterns differ.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain why they differ. C states the reason: so sailors can distinguish them. A describes the difference without saying why. B notes the patterns differ without the reason. D notes the shared interval and different patterns but not the purpose. Trick: A is the strongest distractor -- it precisely describes the difference, but the question asks why, not what.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 74

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Archaeologist Selma O Briain excavated a Bronze Age settlement in Ireland.
- She found postholes marking where wooden houses once stood.
- She also found charred grain in storage pits.
- Radiocarbon dating of the grain placed the settlement at around 1500 BCE.
- The grain showed the settlers grew barley and wheat.

The student wants to explain what the charred grain revealed about the settlement. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Selma O Briain excavated a Bronze Age settlement in Ireland and found postholes marking where wooden houses once stood.

B: The charred grain was found in storage pits at the settlement, alongside postholes from wooden structures.

C: O Briain's excavation of a Bronze Age settlement in Ireland yielded artifacts that helped date the site and identify its inhabitants' practices.

D: The charred grain, dated to around 1500 BCE, showed that the settlers grew barley and wheat.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: what the grain revealed. D gives both revelations: the date (around 1500 BCE) and the crops (barley and wheat). A discusses postholes, not grain. B describes where the grain was found but not what it revealed. C vaguely says artifacts helped 'date the site and identify practices' without specifics. Trick: C sounds comprehensive but is too vague to count as explaining what the grain specifically revealed.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 75

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Venus is the second planet from the Sun.
- It is the hottest planet in the solar system.
- Its thick atmosphere traps heat, raising surface temperatures above 460 degrees C.
- A day on Venus is longer than its year.

The student wants to explain why Venus is so hot. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Venus's thick atmosphere traps heat, raising surface temperatures above 460 degrees C.

B: Venus is the hottest planet in the solar system and the second planet from the Sun.

C: A day on Venus is longer than its year, and its surface temperatures exceed 460 degrees C.

D: Venus is the second planet from the Sun, which contributes to the extreme conditions found on its surface.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain why it is hot. A gives the cause (thick atmosphere traps heat) and the effect (460+ degrees). B states it is hot but not why. C combines day length and temperature, but day length does not explain the heat. D says 'second from the Sun' implies solar proximity causes the heat, but the notes attribute it to the atmosphere. Trick: D is the main trap -- it offers a plausible-sounding but incorrect causal claim (proximity to the Sun), when the notes attribute the heat to the atmosphere.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 76

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Choreographer Idris Bello created two dance works about migration.
- Crossings (2017) is performed by a solo dancer.
- Currents (2021) is performed by an ensemble of twenty dancers.
- Both works use recorded interviews with migrants as their soundtrack.

The student wants to emphasize a similarity between the two works. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: Crossings is a solo work, while Currents is performed by twenty dancers, yet both address the theme of migration.
- B: Both Crossings and Currents use recorded interviews with migrants as their soundtrack.
- C: Idris Bello created two dance works, Crossings and Currents, that differ in scale but share a common subject.
- D: Crossings, performed by a solo dancer, premiered in 2017, and Currents, performed by an ensemble, premiered in 2021.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize a similarity. B names the shared element (recorded interviews as soundtrack). A mentions both address migration but leads with a difference (solo vs. ensemble). C says they 'share a common subject' but is vague. D gives dates and performer counts (differences). Trick: A is the strongest distractor -- it ends with a similarity (migration) but opens with a difference, so it does not emphasize the similarity.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 77

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Physicist Talia Rosen studies how sand dunes move.
- Wind pushes sand grains up the gentle windward slope of a dune.
- Grains then tumble down the steep leeward slope, called the slip face.
- Because sand is added on one side and lost on the other, the entire dune slowly migrates downwind.

The student wants to explain why sand dunes migrate. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: Wind pushes sand grains up the gentle windward slope of a dune, and the grains then tumble down the steep leeward side.
- B: Talia Rosen studies how sand dunes move, including the process by which they slowly migrate downwind.
- C: Because wind moves grains from a dune's windward slope to its leeward slip face, the whole dune slowly migrates downwind.
- D: Sand dunes have two distinct sides: a gentle windward slope where sand accumulates and a steep leeward slope called the slip face.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain why dunes migrate. C links cause (wind moves grains from one side to the other) to effect (entire dune migrates). A describes the process but never states the resulting migration. B says they migrate but not why. D describes dune anatomy but not migration. Trick: A is the main trap -- it describes the grain movement accurately but stops before drawing the conclusion about dune migration.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 78

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The tuatara is a reptile found only in New Zealand.
- It is the last surviving member of an ancient order of reptiles.
- Its relatives died out around 60 million years ago.
- The tuatara can live for over a century.

The student wants to emphasize the tuatara's evolutionary uniqueness. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The tuatara can live for over a century and is found only in New Zealand.

B: The tuatara is the last surviving member of an ancient order of reptiles whose other members died out around 60 million years ago.

C: The tuatara's relatives died out around 60 million years ago, making it one of the world's oldest reptile lineages.

D: The tuatara is a reptile found only in New Zealand, where it has lived for millions of years.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize evolutionary uniqueness. D states it is the sole survivor of an extinct order (60 million years ago). A discusses lifespan and location, not evolution. D says it has 'lived for millions of years' (misrepresentation -- the species has, but that is not what the notes say). C says 'one of the oldest lineages' but the notes say it is the last member, not merely one of the oldest. Trick: C slightly misrepresents -- the notes say 'last surviving member,' not merely 'one of the oldest.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 79

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 2024, materials engineer Lucia Ferro tested a new bicycle-frame alloy.
- The new alloy weighed 18% less than the standard aluminum frame.
- It withstood the same stress load as the standard frame in strength tests.
- Ferro noted that the new alloy costs more to produce.

The student wants to emphasize that the new alloy was lighter without being weaker. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The new alloy weighed 18% less than the standard aluminum frame yet withstood the same stress load in strength tests.

B: Lucia Ferro tested a new bicycle-frame alloy in 2024 and found that it differed from standard aluminum in several respects.

C: Although the new alloy costs more to produce, it weighed 18% less than the standard aluminum frame.

D: Ferro noted that the new alloy costs more to produce, a trade-off for its reduced weight.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: lighter WITHOUT being weaker. A gives both: 18% lighter AND same stress load. B is vague ('differed in several respects'). C mentions the lighter weight but pairs it with cost, not strength. D focuses on cost, not strength. Trick: C is a strong distractor -- it mentions the 18% weight reduction, but it pairs that fact with the cost downside rather than the strength equivalence the goal asks about.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 80

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two accounts describe the founding of a medieval town.
- A chronicle written in 1300 says the town was founded by a duke in 1150.
- A recently discovered charter, dated 1130, already refers to the town as established.
- The charter's date shows the chronicle's founding date is too late.
- Historians now consider the charter the more reliable source.

The student wants to explain why historians favor the charter over the chronicle. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: A chronicle written in 1300 says a duke founded the town in 1150, while a recently discovered charter, dated 1130, refers to the town as already established.

B: Because the 1130 charter already refers to the town as established, it shows the chronicle's founding date of 1150 is too late -- so historians favor the charter.

C: Historians have two accounts of the town's founding: a chronicle from 1300 and a charter from 1130, each offering a different perspective.

D: The recently discovered charter provides an earlier date for the town's existence than the chronicle, leading historians to reconsider the town's origins.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain why historians favor the charter. B gives the reasoning: the 1130 charter predates the chronicle's claimed founding of 1150, proving the chronicle is wrong. A presents both sources but does not state why one is favored. C frames the sources as equal perspectives. D notes the charter is earlier but does not fully explain the logical chain. Trick: A is the strongest distractor -- it lays out the key facts but stops just short of stating the inference that makes the charter more reliable.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 81

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The monarch butterfly migrates thousands of kilometers each year.
- Monarchs from North America travel to central Mexico for the winter.
- No single butterfly completes the whole round trip.
- The journey spans several generations.

The student wants to emphasize that the migration takes more than one generation. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: Monarchs from North America travel thousands of kilometers to central Mexico each winter.
- B: The monarch butterfly undertakes one of the longest migrations of any insect species.
- C: No single monarch completes the whole round trip; the journey spans several generations.
- D: The monarch butterfly migrates to central Mexico, a destination that remains consistent from year to year.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize multi-generational migration. C states that no single butterfly completes the trip and that it spans several generations. A gives distance and destination but not the generational aspect. B describes it as long but adds no generational detail. D discusses destination consistency. Trick: none of the distractors address generations at all, making this a clear identification question at Easy difficulty.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 82

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Ceramic artist Hyun-woo Park makes large vases.
- His early vases, from the 2000s, used a single glaze color.
- His recent vases layer multiple glazes that shift color as light changes.
- Both styles are fired in a traditional wood-burning kiln.

The student wants to contrast Park's early and recent vases. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Both Park's early and recent vases are fired in a traditional wood-burning kiln, a process that has defined his career.

B: Hyun-woo Park makes large vases using a traditional wood-burning kiln, a method he has employed since the 2000s.

C: Park's recent vases layer multiple glazes that shift color as light changes, making them visually dynamic.

D: Whereas Park's early vases used a single glaze color, his recent vases layer multiple glazes that shift color as light changes.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: contrast early vs. recent. D directly contrasts single-glaze (early) vs. multi-glaze (recent). A emphasizes a shared trait (kiln). B describes a consistent method. C describes only the recent vases. Trick: A is the main trap -- it mentions both eras ('early and recent') but highlights what they share rather than how they differ.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 83

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Epidemiologist Nour Khalil studied a cholera outbreak in a 19th-century city.
- She mapped where cases occurred.
- Cases clustered tightly around one public water pump.
- Few cases appeared near other pumps in the city.
- Khalil concluded the pump was the likely source of the outbreak.

The student wants to explain the evidence behind Khalil's conclusion. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A: Because cases clustered tightly around one public water pump -- and few appeared near others -- Khalil concluded that pump was the likely source.
- B: Nour Khalil studied a cholera outbreak in a 19th-century city and concluded that a public water pump was the likely source.
- C: Khalil mapped the locations of cholera cases in the city, a research method that allowed her to identify patterns in the outbreak.
- D: Epidemiologist Nour Khalil used mapping to study a cholera outbreak, focusing on the distribution of cases relative to public water pumps.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: the evidence behind the conclusion. A gives the evidence (clustering around one pump, few cases near others) and links it to the conclusion. B gives the conclusion but skips the evidence. C describes the method (mapping) but not the evidence it produced. D describes the research focus but not the specific findings. Trick: B is the strongest distractor -- it states the conclusion directly but omits the evidence, which is what the goal asks for.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 84

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Coral reefs are sometimes called the rainforests of the sea.
- They cover less than 1% of the ocean floor.
- They support about 25% of all marine species.
- This diversity gives them their nickname.

The student wants to emphasize the biodiversity of coral reefs. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Coral reefs are sometimes called the rainforests of the sea, a nickname that reflects certain qualities of these marine ecosystems.

B: Though they cover less than 1% of the ocean floor, coral reefs support about 25% of all marine species.

C: Coral reefs, which cover less than 1% of the ocean floor, have earned the nickname 'rainforests of the sea.'

D: Coral reefs are marine ecosystems that have been given a memorable nickname because of their ecological importance.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: emphasize biodiversity. B highlights the contrast between small coverage (less than 1%) and high species support (25%), which powerfully emphasizes biodiversity. A mentions the nickname but not the data. C gives the coverage figure and nickname but omits the 25% species figure. D is vague ('ecological importance'). Trick: C includes the 1% figure but drops the 25% that makes the biodiversity claim concrete.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 85

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Linguist Omar Said documents endangered languages.
- The language Taku had only twelve fluent speakers in 2010.
- Said recorded stories, songs, and everyday conversations in Taku.
- A community school now uses his recordings to teach Taku to children.

The student wants to explain how Said's recordings are being used. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Omar Said documents endangered languages, including Taku, which had only twelve fluent speakers in 2010.

B: Said recorded stories, songs, and everyday conversations in the Taku language to create an archive of the endangered language.

C: A community school now uses Said's recordings of stories, songs, and conversations to teach Taku to children.

D: The Taku language had only twelve fluent speakers in 2010, making it one of the endangered languages Said has documented.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: how the recordings are being used. C states the use: a community school teaches Taku to children using the recordings. A introduces Said and Taku but not the use. B describes what was recorded and adds 'archive' (not in the notes). D gives speaker count. Trick: B is the main distractor -- it describes the recordings' content, which sounds relevant, but it invents a purpose ('create an archive') rather than stating the actual use.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 86

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two hypotheses explain why some birds lay eggs of different colors within one clutch.
- The 'signal hypothesis' holds that color differences help parents recognize their own eggs.
- The 'camouflage hypothesis' holds that varied colors make eggs harder for predators to spot as a group.
- A study found that nests with mixed-color eggs suffered fewer predator raids than uniform nests.
- The study found no evidence that parents used color to recognize eggs.

The student wants to note which hypothesis the study supported. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Two hypotheses -- the signal hypothesis and the camouflage hypothesis -- attempt to explain why some birds lay differently colored eggs.

B: A study of egg-color variation found that nests with mixed-color eggs suffered fewer predator raids and that parents used color to recognize their own eggs.

C: The signal hypothesis holds that egg-color differences help parents recognize their own eggs, while the camouflage hypothesis focuses on predator deterrence.

D: The study supported the camouflage hypothesis: nests with mixed-color eggs suffered fewer predator raids than uniform nests, while no evidence supported the signal hypothesis.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: which hypothesis was supported. D names the camouflage hypothesis, gives the supporting evidence (fewer raids), and notes the signal hypothesis was unsupported. A introduces both hypotheses without results. B misrepresents the findings -- the study found no evidence parents used color (not the opposite). C defines the hypotheses without the study results. Trick: B is a deliberate misrepresentation trap -- it reverses the signal-hypothesis finding, claiming parents DID use color when the notes say they did not.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 87

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: EASY

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The didgeridoo is a wind instrument developed by Aboriginal Australians.
- It is traditionally made from a hollowed-out tree branch.
- Players use a technique called circular breathing to produce a continuous sound.
- The instrument is thousands of years old.

The student wants to explain how players produce a continuous sound on the didgeridoo. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Players use a technique called circular breathing to produce a continuous sound on the didgeridoo.

B: The didgeridoo is a wind instrument developed by Aboriginal Australians and is traditionally made from a hollowed-out tree branch.

C: Thousands of years old, the didgeridoo is notable for the continuous sound it produces when played.

D: The didgeridoo, a wind instrument made from a hollowed-out branch, has been played by Aboriginal Australians for thousands of years.

ANSWER: A

EXPLANATION: Goal: explain how players produce the sound. A names the technique (circular breathing) and links it to the continuous sound. B describes the instrument's origin and material. C mentions the continuous sound but not how it is produced. D gives history and materials. Trick: C is the main distractor -- it mentions 'continuous sound' but omits the technique that produces it, which is the 'how.'

END QUESTION

QUESTION 88

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- In 2023, hydrologist Grace Mbeki studied two watersheds in Kenya.
- The forested watershed released water into rivers steadily all year.
- The deforested watershed flooded in the rainy season and dried up in the dry season.
- Mbeki attributed the difference to the forest's ability to store and slowly release water.

The student wants to present Mbeki's reasoning for the difference between the watersheds. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The forested watershed released water steadily all year, unlike the deforested watershed, which experienced flooding and drought.

B: Mbeki attributed the steadier water flow of the forested watershed to the forest's ability to store and slowly release water.

C: In 2023, Grace Mbeki studied two watersheds in Kenya to understand how land cover affects water flow patterns.

D: The deforested watershed flooded in the rainy season and dried up in the dry season, while the forested watershed did not.

ANSWER: B

EXPLANATION: Goal: present Mbeki's reasoning. B attributes the reasoning to Mbeki and states her mechanism (forest stores and slowly releases water). A and D describe the difference but not the reasoning behind it. C describes the study's purpose, not its reasoning. Trick: A is the strongest distractor -- it accurately describes the contrast, but describing what happened is not the same as presenting why.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 89

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: HARD

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- Two manuscripts preserve an ancient Greek poem.
- Manuscript A, copied in the 900s, is complete but contains many scribal errors.
- Manuscript B, copied in the 1100s, is missing its final pages but is carefully written.
- Scholars use Manuscript B to correct errors in Manuscript A.
- They rely on Manuscript A for the poem's ending, which Manuscript B lacks.

The student wants to explain how scholars use the two manuscripts together. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: Manuscript A is complete but error-filled, while Manuscript B is accurate but incomplete -- each preserving the poem differently.

B: Two manuscripts, one from the 900s and one from the 1100s, preserve an ancient Greek poem in different conditions.

C: Scholars correct Manuscript A's errors using the carefully written Manuscript B, while relying on Manuscript A for the ending that Manuscript B lacks.

D: Manuscript B, copied in the 1100s, is missing its final pages, which means scholars must turn to Manuscript A for the poem's conclusion.

ANSWER: C

EXPLANATION: Goal: how scholars use them together. C describes both uses: B corrects A's errors, and A supplies the ending B lacks. A describes the manuscripts' conditions but not how scholars use them. B introduces the manuscripts without their scholarly use. D explains only one direction of the relationship (A for the ending). Trick: D is the strongest distractor -- it accurately describes one way scholars use the pair, but the goal is 'together,' requiring both directions.

END QUESTION

QUESTION 90

SECTION: READING_WRITING

CATEGORY: SAT Practice: Rhetorical Synthesis

DIFFICULTY: MEDIUM

PROMPT: While researching a topic, a student has taken the following notes:

- The Iron Bridge in England opened in 1781.
- It was the first major bridge built from cast iron.
- Earlier bridges were typically built from stone or wood.
- The Iron Bridge showed that iron could be used for large-scale construction.

The student wants to explain the historical significance of the Iron Bridge. Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

A: The Iron Bridge in England opened in 1781, at a time when most bridges were made of stone or wood.

B: Earlier bridges were typically built from stone or wood, materials that had been used in construction for centuries.

C: The Iron Bridge, which opened in 1781, was constructed from cast iron rather than the stone or wood used in earlier bridges.

D: As the first major bridge built from cast iron, the Iron Bridge showed that iron could be used for large-scale construction.

ANSWER: D

EXPLANATION: Goal: historical significance. D states what made it significant: first cast-iron bridge, demonstrated iron's viability for large construction. A gives date and context but not significance. B discusses earlier materials. C notes the material difference but does not state the broader significance. Trick: C is the main trap -- it correctly notes the shift from stone/wood to iron, but it stops at the material fact without stating what that shift demonstrated.

END QUESTION